

`helix\_design` — the decoupled, reusable HelixVPN design-system submodule

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Master technical specification — Volume 10 (Design System), nano-detail anchor document. This doc specifies **vasic-digital/helix_design** as a *fully decoupled, project-not-aware, reusable* design-system submodule: its purpose and scope, why it is a separate submodule (§11.4.28 equal-codebase + decoupling, §11.4.74 catalogue-first reuse), its repository layout, the decoupling invariants (NO HelixVPN-specific context leaks into the submodule — brand values are *injected* as a token preset per §11.4.28(B)), its semver/versioning policy, the consumption model (how Client / Console / Connector — and **any future app** — incorporate it), and its relationship to the mandatory OpenDesign design-and-refinement system (§11.4.162, detailed in the sibling [opendesign-foundation.md]). SPEC-ONLY: it describes **what to build**, not the shipping artifact. No bluff: every external fact about OpenDesign is verified in the sibling doc and cited; anything unproven is tagged UNVERIFIED (§11.4.6).

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0. Position, ownership, and invariants

helix_design is the **single source of design truth** for every HelixVPN user-facing surface. The Flutter helix-ui workspace already names a helix_design *package* [04_CLIENT §1.1/§2.1] — but per the operator mandate (2026-06-25, §11.4.162) and [MASTER_INDEX Volume 10], the design system is promoted to a **standalone, decoupled, reusable submodule** at vasic-digital/helix_design (snake_case flat per §11.4.29) that the Flutter helix_design *package* re-exports for Dart consumers, and that **non-Flutter** surfaces (native shims, future apps) consume directly via the polyglot token bundle.

0.1 What this document owns vs. consumes

#	Contract	Owned here	Consumed from / by
O-A1	The submodule's existence, identity, and flat layout at vasic-digital/helix_design	§1, §4	—
O-A2	The decoupling invariants — no HelixVPN context inside the submodule	§3	enforced against the whole submodule tree
O-A3	The token-tier model (primitive → semantic → component) + brand-preset injection	§5	deepened in [design-tokens.md], [color-system.md]
O-A4	The export-form set (JSON source → CSS /	§6	pipeline deepened in [token-export-pipeline.md]

#	Contract	Owned here	Consumed from / by
	Dart / Swift / Compose / ArkTS / C-Qt)		
O-A5	The consumption recipe (git submodule add, install_upstreams, pull tokens)	§7, §9	every consuming app + future app
O-A6	The relationship to OpenDesign	§10	detailed in [opendesign-foundation.md]
C-B1	The OpenDesign tool facts (what it is, how it is consumed)	—	[opendesign-foundation.md] (web-verified)
C-B2	The connection-state palette  TunnelStatus mapping	—	[04_CLIENT §2.1], [02_ORCH §4.1] (5-variant core::TunnelStatus wire enum → 7-variant ffi::TunnelStatus Dart-facing)
C-B3	The helix-ui package graph that re-exports the Dart bundle	—	[04_CLIENT §1.1/§2.1]

0.2 Non-negotiable invariants

#	Invariant	Source
DS-I1	helix_design contains NO project-specific HelixVPN context. It ships generic tokens / themes / components; HelixVPN brand values arrive as an <i>injected</i> token preset (config), never hardcoded.	§11.4.28(B)
DS-I2	OpenDesign is the only design-and-refinement system. No ad-hoc CSS, no one-off design tools. Missing patterns extend OpenDesign upstream (§11.4.74), never reimplemented in-project.	§11.4.162
DS-I3	Every component & color ships a light AND a dark variant. A token, component, or screen with only one theme is incomplete.	§11.4.162
DS-I4	Elements MUST NOT overlap; labels MUST NOT be overlaid. The layout-integrity rule is a release blocker, asserted by visual-regression ([visual-regression-and-qa.md]).	§11.4.162

#	Invariant	Source
DS-15	All UI changes carry visual-regression coverage. Golden screenshots + token-drift assertions gate every design change.	§11.4.162, §11.4.4(b)
DS-16	One canonical token source; every consumable form is a derived export. Hand-editing a derived form (e.g. the Dart ThemeData) instead of the source is forbidden — it is a build-derivative per §11.4.30/§11.4.77, regenerated by the pipeline.	§6, §11.4.12
DS-17	Honest boundary — <code>helix_design</code> governs <i>design tokens, themes, components, and their visual correctness</i> . It does NOT assert functional correctness (§11.4.27), accessibility <i>behaviour</i> beyond contrast/labels it can statically check, or UI-driven test methodology (§11.4.48/.49).	§11.4.162 honest boundary

1. Purpose & scope

1.1 Purpose

`helix_design` exists so that **every** HelixVPN user-facing application — the **Client** (end-user VPN app on all 8 platforms: iOS, macOS, Android, Windows, Linux, Web, HarmonyOS, Aurora), the **Console** (admin web app), and the **Connector** (appliance config UI) — renders from **one** design source: the same palette (light + dark), the same type ramp, the same spacing/radius/elevation/motion scale, and the same component anatomy, **without** any of those three apps owning a private copy of the design tokens [SPEC roles]. A change to a brand color, a contrast fix, or a new component variant is made **once** in `helix_design` and propagates — through the export pipeline (§6) — to all three apps and all 8 platforms.

1.2 Scope (what the submodule contains)

In scope:

1. **The canonical token source** — primitive → semantic → component tiers, with the light + dark theme model (§5; schema deepened in [design-tokens.md]).
2. **The HelixVPN brand preset** — the *one* HelixVPN-flavoured config that injects the brand seed color, the connection-state palette, the type face choices, etc., into the generic token tiers (§5.4). This is the *only* place HelixVPN-specific values live, and it is structured as **injectable config**, not as inline submodule values (DS-I1).

3. **The exporters** — the generators that emit the token source into every consumable form (JSON / CSS / Dart / Swift / Compose / ArkTS / C-Qt; §6).
4. **The component library specs + reference implementations** — anatomy, states, variants, light+dark, a11y (deepened in [component-library.md]). Reference implementations are per-platform where the component is platform-native; otherwise the spec + tokens are the deliverable and each app composes the widget from tokens.
5. **The asset corpus** — icon set, illustration sources, fonts (or font references), in the asset forms each platform needs (deepened in [assets-and-deliverables.md]).
6. **The OpenDesign-native design-system folder** — the DESIGN.md + tokens.css form OpenDesign consumes/refines (§10; deepened in [opendesign-foundation.md]).
7. **The visual-regression + token-drift test suite** that gates every change (§12).
8. **Docs** — every Volume 10 nano-detail document ships with the submodule (so the design system is self-documenting and reusable by any future project).

Out of scope (lives in the consuming app, not the submodule):

- The Riverpod projectUiState state machine and UiConnectionState projection — that is *application* logic, owned by helix_domain [04_CLIENT §7]. helix_design provides the colorForUiState-style *token map*, not the state machine that drives it.
 - Per-app navigation / IA / routing — owned by each app.
 - FFI, control-plane wire, tunnel lifecycle — Volumes 2/3/4.
-

2. Why a separate submodule (§11.4.28 / §11.4.74)

2.1 Reuse (§11.4.74 catalogue-first)

The design system is **not** HelixVPN-specific in its machinery. A palette-tiering model, a polyglot token exporter, a light/dark theming engine, and an icon pipeline are exactly the kind of capability §11.4.74 says must be **reusable across ≥3 unrelated projects** and therefore must live in the vasic-digital catalogue, not buried in one product. Any future Helix-ecosystem app (a different VPN client, an admin tool, a marketing site, a device dashboard) incorporates helix_design, swaps the brand preset (§5.4), and inherits the entire token/theme/component/export machinery

for free. Burying the design system inside `helix-ui` would force the next project to either re-implement it (a §11.4.74 duplicate-implementation violation) or depend on a VPN app it does not need.

2.2 Equal-codebase + decoupling (§11.4.28)

Per §11.4.28(A), `helix_design` — once it is an owned submodule — is an **equal part** of the codebase: same anti-bluff testing, same docs, same multi-upstream push discipline as the main repo. Per §11.4.28(B), it **MUST** stay **project-not-aware** and **fully testable in isolation** — which forces the clean seam this volume specifies: generic tiers in the submodule, HelixVPN values injected as config (DS-I1, §5.4). The decoupling is not a nicety; it is the mechanism that makes the reuse of §2.1 *real* rather than aspirational.

2.3 Flat-layout requirement (§11.4.28(C) / §11.4.29)

Per §11.4.28(C) nested own-org submodule chains are FORBIDDEN; the dependency is reached from the **parent project root** at a flat path. `helix_design` is therefore added at `helix_vpn/helix_design/` (or `helix_vpn/submodules/helix_design/`), `snake_case` (§11.4.29), and the Flutter `helix-ui` workspace's `helix_design` *package* depends on it via a `path/replace` directive — it does **not** nest `helix_design` inside `helix-ui` as a sub-submodule.

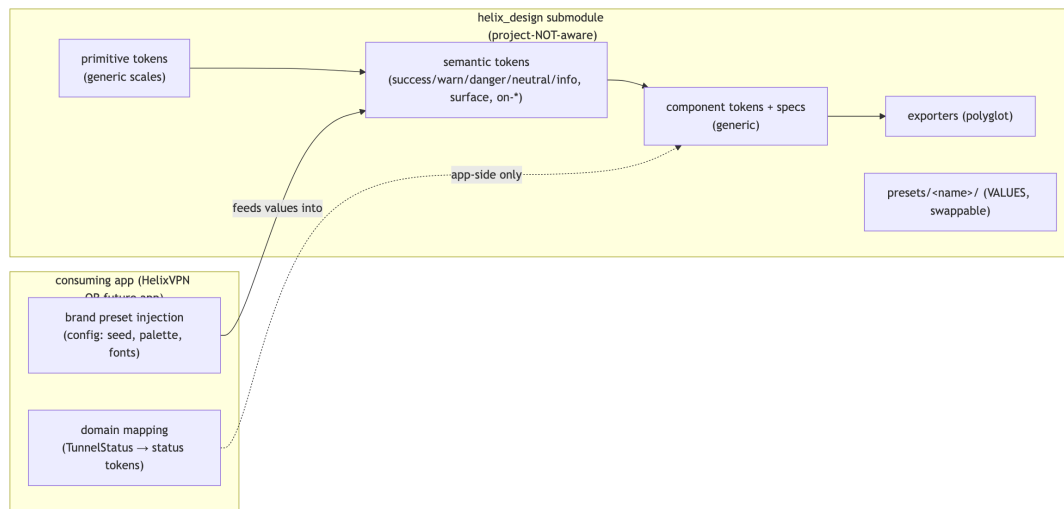
D-DESIGN-1 (open). Two viable layouts for "the Flutter package vs. the polyglot bundle": **(a)** a *single* `helix_design` submodule that contains BOTH the Flutter package (`packages/flutter/`) AND the polyglot token/asset bundle (`tokens/`, `export/`, `assets/`), the Flutter `helix-ui` re-exporting `packages/flutter/`; **or (b)** two submodules — `helix_design` (polyglot source + exporters) and `helix_design_flutter` (the Dart package that consumes the generated Dart export). §11.4.28(C) forbids nesting but permits sibling flat submodules. This document specifies layout **(a)** as the default (one submodule, one design truth, fewer moving parts) and flags (b) as the alternative if the Dart package's release cadence must diverge from the token source's. Resolved at the Volume-10 design review. UNVERIFIED until ratified.

3. The decoupling invariants (no project context leaks)

DS-I1 is the load-bearing rule. Concretely, **inside the helix_design submodule tree** the following are FORBIDDEN (each is a §11.4.28(B) decoupling violation, caught by the pre-commit decoupling grep CM-OWNED-SUBMODULE-DECOUPLING):

Forbidden inside the submodule	Why	Where it goes instead
The literal strings HelixVPN, helix_vpn, helixvpn in token names / component logic / exporter code	project context leak	the brand-preset <i>config file</i> (§5.4) may carry the product name as a <i>value</i> ; the machinery may not
A hardcoded brand seed color in a <i>primitive/semantic</i> token	couples the generic tiers to one product	the brand seed is a preset value injected into the semantic tier (§5.4)
A TunnelStatus-shaped enum or any VPN-domain type	VPN domain leak	the connection-state <i>palette</i> is generic "status" tokens (success/warn/danger/neutral/info); the <i>mapping</i> to TunnelStatus lives in helix_domain [04_CLIENT §7.2]
Import of any helix-core / helix_api / control-plane package	inverts the dependency direction	the submodule depends on NOTHING Helix-product-side (it is a leaf)
A hardcoded HelixVPN server list, region name, or asset path	project context	app-side config

What the submodule **MAY** contain: generic design primitives, a *named* default brand preset folder (e.g. presets/helix/ — a value, swappable), generic component specs, generic status-token semantics. The test that DS-I1 holds: **a throwaway consuming project that injects a *different* brand preset and builds all export forms green, runs the submodule's own tests against that layout, and contains no reference back to HelixVPN** (the §11.4.31 manifest-paired Challenge pattern).



4. Repository layout

Layout **(a)** of D-DESIGN-1 (single submodule). Every directory is generic-by-default; the presets/helix/ folder holds the only HelixVPN-flavoured *values* (and even those are structured so a future app drops a sibling presets/<x>/).

```

helix_design/                                # vasic-digital/
helix_design (flat submodule)
├─ README.md                                # what it is, install, the
per-app pull recipe (§9)
├─ CLAUDE.md  AGENTS.md  QWEN.md  GEMINI.md  # inherit
constitution (§11.4.157)
├─ helix-deps.yaml                          # §11.4.31 dependency
manifest (own-org deps, if any)
├─ LICENSE  CHANGELOG.md  VERSION          # semver source of truth (§8)
├─ upstreams/                              # §11.4.36 push-mirror
recipes (one .sh per upstream)
├─ ┌─ github.sh  gitlab.sh  gitflic.sh  gitverse.sh
├─ tokens/                                  # — THE CANONICAL SOURCE
OF TRUTH —
├─ ┌─ primitive/                          # raw scales: color ramps,
type sizes, space, radius...
├─ ┌─ ┌─ color.json  type.json  space.json  radius.json
├─ ┌─ ┌─ elevation.json  motion.json  zindex.json
breakpoints.json
├─ ┌─ semantic/                          # role tokens that
reference primitives (light + dark)
├─ ┌─ ┌─ color.light.json  color.dark.json
├─ ┌─ ┌─ type.json  space.json  elevation.json  motion.json
├─ ┌─ component/                        # per-component tokens that
reference semantics
├─ ┌─ ┌─ connect_button.json  status_chip.json
exit_picker.json  ...

```


[illegible]

drift + ally-contrast (§12)

└─ golden/ drift/ contrast/ decoupling/

dist/ is a build-derivative. Per DS-I6 + §11.4.30, the dist/** export forms are *gitignored* and regenerated by `pnpm export` (the §11.4.77 regeneration mechanism, declared in `.gitignore-meta/dist.yaml`). The **source** (tokens/**, presets/**, export/**) is tracked; the *outputs* are not. A consumer that needs a pinned binary bundle pulls a tagged *release artifact* (§8), not the git tree's dist/.

D-DESIGN-2 (open). Whether dist/ is gitignored-and-regenerated (above) or *committed* (so a Dart consumer pulling the submodule gets the generated .dart with no Node toolchain). Trade-off: §11.4.30 forbids versioned build derivatives, but a Dart-only consumer should not need pnpm. Resolution candidate: gitignore dist/, but publish the Flutter package (packages/flutter/lib/ with a *checked-in* generated `helix_tokens.dart`) as the pub-consumable form, treating the Flutter package's generated Dart as a *source-of-the-package* (regenerated in CI-equivalent local pre-tag sweep, §11.4.156). UNVERIFIED until the Volume-10 review ratifies.

5. Token tiers, theming, and the brand-preset injection model

5.1 Three tiers (deepened in [design-tokens.md])



- **Primitive** — raw, meaningless values: color ramps (e.g. `blue.50...900`), the type size scale, the 4-base spacing scale {4, 8, 12, 16, 24, 32, 48}, radii {sm8, md12, lg20, pill999}, motion {fast120, base220, slow360}, elevation 0..3. Mirrors the values already sketched in the Flutter `helix_design` package [04_CLIENT §2.1] but generalised (no brand seed inline — DS-I1).
- **Semantic** — role tokens that *reference* primitives and are **theme-keyed**: a semantic token holds a {light, dark} pair (DS-I3). E.g. `color.surface`, `color.on-surface`, `color.action`, `color.success`, `color.warn`, `color.danger`, `color.neutral`, `color.info`.

- **Component** — per-widget tokens that reference semantic tokens (connectButton.bg, statusChip.fg). A widget reads only component tokens; it never reaches a primitive.

5.2 Light + dark theming (DS-I3)

Theming is a **semantic-tier concern**: every semantic color token carries both a light and a dark value. The export pipeline (§6) emits **two** resolved theme tables per target (a light and a dark map) — never a single theme. A component spec that omits the dark value, or an export that emits only one theme, FAILs the §12 drift gate. Example (semantic source):

```
// tokens/semantic/color.light.json (excerpt) – references
// primitives by name
{
  "color": {
    "surface": { "value": "{color.neutral.50}" },
    "on-surface": { "value": "{color.neutral.900}" },
    "action": { "value": "{color.blue.600}" },
    "success": { "value": "{color.green.600}" },
    "warn": { "value": "{color.amber.600}" },
    "danger": { "value": "{color.red.600}" }
  }
}

// tokens/semantic/color.dark.json – same KEYS, dark-resolved
// values
{
  "color": {
    "surface": { "value": "{color.neutral.900}" },
    "on-surface": { "value": "{color.neutral.50}" },
    "action": { "value": "{color.blue.400}" },
    "success": { "value": "{color.green.400}" },
    "warn": { "value": "{color.amber.400}" },
    "danger": { "value": "{color.red.400}" }
  }
}
```

5.3 Light + dark is also a CONTRAST contract

Light/dark is not just two palettes; each (theme, semantic-on-pair) MUST satisfy WCAG contrast (deepened in [color-system.md]). The §12 contrast test asserts every on-X / X pair (e.g. on-surface / surface) clears the AA threshold in **both** themes — a dark theme that looks fine but fails contrast is a DS-I5 / §11.4.162 failure.

5.4 The brand-preset injection model (DS-I1)

The generic semantic tier references **preset tokens** for the values a brand chooses. The HelixVPN brand preset supplies them; a future app supplies its own. The submodule ships `presets/helix/` as the **default value set**, but the *mechanism* is injection — a consuming project can override the preset path at build time:

```
// presets/helix/brand.json – VALUES (the only HelixVPN-flavoured
// data; swappable)
{
  "brand": {
    "seed":      "#3B5BDB",          // drives the action ramp
    + M3 ColorScheme
    "accent":    "#10B981",
    "fontFamily": { "sans": "Inter", "mono": "JetBrains Mono" },
    "logo":      { "light": "assets/logo/helix-light.svg",
                  "dark":  "assets/logo/helix-dark.svg" },
    "productName": "HelixVPN"      // a VALUE, not machinery
    (DS-I1 ok)
  }
}
```

Illustrative seed values — the canonical brand/semantic hexes live in `[color-system.md]` (brand `#3D5AF1`); a seed need not equal a ramp step.

```
# build with a DIFFERENT brand preset (proves DS-I1 decoupling) –
  §12 decoupling test
pnpm export --preset presets/acme/ # → dist/** carries Acme's
  palette, zero HelixVPN refs
```

5.5 The connection-state palette (generic status tokens)

The 7-variant connection-state palette the Client renders is expressed as **generic status tokens** in the preset (`presets/helix/connection_state.json`), mapped to the FFI `TunnelStatus` **in the app** (`[04_CLIENT §7.2]`), never inside the submodule (DS-I1):

UI state	Status token	Light	Dark	Notes
Disconnected	<code>state.neutral</code>	<code>neutral.600</code>	<code>neutral.400</code>	"Not protected" — grey
Connecting / Handshaking	<code>state.warn</code>	<code>amber.600</code>	<code>amber.400</code>	in-motion
Connected (direct)	<code>state.success</code>	<code>green.600</code> <code>green.700</code>	<code>green.400</code> <code>green.300</code>	safe

UI state	Status token	Light	Dark	Notes
Connected (relay)	state.success-alt			sub-shade for relay path (D-UI-3 in 04_CLIENT)
Reconnecting	state.warn-pulse	amber.600	amber.400	animated pulse (motion token)
Down	state.caution	orange.600	orange.400	recoverable fault
Danger	state.danger	red.600	red.400	leak / kill-switch tripped

These are descriptive labels, not token keys — the canonical token keys are `color.semantic.state.<variant>.fill` per [design-tokens.md] §8.

The submodule provides the *tokens*; the projection is layered: the **Rust FFI StatusProjector produces the 7-variant `ffi::TunnelStatus` from the 5-variant core::`TunnelStatus` (it adds **Disconnected** and **Danger**)** [ffi-surface.md §3.2/§3.3], and only the `Connected{direct|relay}` sub-shade is app-side rendering in `helix_domain`'s `projectUiState` [04_CLIENT §7.2].

6. The export forms (one source → every consumable form)

Per the Volume 10 mandate, the canonical JSON token source is emitted into **every** consumable form so each platform incorporates tokens **directly** (no platform re-types a color by hand — DS-I6). Pipeline deepened in [token-export-pipeline.md]; here is the form contract:

Target	Output	Consumed by	Theme handling
JSON (Style-Dictionary-class source)	dist/json/tokens.json	the source-of-truth other exporters read; tooling	both themes as keyed maps

Target	Output	Consumed by	Theme handling
CSS custom properties	dist/css/ helix.css	Console Web (Flutter web + any web surface)	: root (light) + [data-theme=dark] (dark)
Dart	dist/dart/ helix_tokens.dart + ThemeData/ ThemeExtension	helix-ui (Client/ Console/ Connector Flutter) [04_CLIENT §2.1]	HelixTheme.light() / .dark() ThemeExtension
SwiftUI	dist/swift/ HelixTokens.swift	iOS/macOS native shim surfaces (NE config UI, widgets)	Color assets + @Environment(\.colorScheme)
Jetpack Compose	dist/compose/ HelixTokens.kt	Android native surfaces (quick- settings tile, notification)	lightColors() / darkColors()
ArkTS	dist/arkts/ helix_tokens.ets	HarmonyOS native surfaces	resource qualifiers dark/
C / Qt	dist/cqt/ helix_tokens.h + .qml	Aurora Qt/ C++ surfaces	C #define + QML Theme singleton

Why polyglot, not Flutter-only. Flutter helix-ui covers the *app* surfaces, but several surfaces are platform-native and never see Dart: the iOS/macOS Network-Extension config UI and widgets (SwiftUI), the Android quick-settings tile + notification (Compose), the HarmonyOS VPN-ability surfaces (ArkTS), and the Aurora Qt backend's UI (C/Qt) [04_CLIENT §4.4 native shims]. Each must render the **same** palette as the Flutter app — so the token source must emit a native form for each. A Flutter-only token package would leave those surfaces to hand-copy colors, the exact drift DS-I6 forbids.

Honest boundary on OpenDesign and the polyglot forms. OpenDesign **does not itself emit Dart/Swift/Compose/ArkTS/C-Qt** (web-verified — see [opendesign-foundation.md] § Sources).

OpenDesign's native artifact form is `DESIGN.md` + `tokens.css` (CSS custom properties). Therefore the polyglot exporters (`export/targets/*.ts`) are **helix_design's own** Style-Dictionary-class pipeline, fed by the canonical JSON source, with `tokens.css` as one *input/round-trip* form to/from OpenDesign (§10). If a future requirement is "OpenDesign itself must emit a Compose form", that is an **extend-OpenDesign-upstream** task per §11.4.74 (§10.4), not an in-helix_design reimplementaion. This split is stated plainly so no reader assumes OpenDesign ships a multi-language token compiler it does not (§11.4.6).

7. upstreams/, install_upstreams, and helix-deps.yaml

7.1 upstreams/ + install_upstreams (§11.4.36)

As an owned submodule, helix_design ships an `upstreams/` directory with one recipe `*.sh` per push mirror (GitHub + GitLab + GitFlic + GitVerse per the §11.4.28 owned-org set). On clone/add, `install_upstreams` is invoked from the submodule root to configure every mirror as a push remote (§11.4.36 mandate). Skipping it silently breaks §2.1 multi-upstream push.

```
# after the consuming project adds helix_design as a submodule:
cd helix_vpn/helix_design && install_upstreams      # configures
    all push mirrors
git remote -v | grep -c push                        # expect ==
    number of mirrors
```

7.2 helix-deps.yaml (§11.4.31)

helix_design declares its own own-org dependencies (if any) in a machine-readable manifest so a consuming project can reconstruct the dependency graph from the parent root (no nested own-org chains — §11.4.28(C)). For a leaf design system this is typically *empty of own-org deps* (the submodule depends on nothing Helix-product-side, DS-I1) — but the file **MUST** exist and declare third-party build deps (Node/pnpm toolchain, the Style-Dictionary-class library, weasyprint/pandoc for doc export).

```
# helix_design/helix-deps.yaml
schema_version: 1
deps: []          # leaf: no own-org runtime deps (DS-I1)
build_toolchain:
  - { name: "node", version:
      "~24" }      # OpenDesign + exporter toolchain (verified §10)
```

```

- { name: "pnpm", version: "10.x" }
transitive_handling:
  recursive: true
  conflict_resolution: operator-required
language_specific_subtree: true # packages/flutter/ is
                                a pub package

```

8. Semver & versioning policy

helix_design is versioned **independently** of the HelixVPN product (it is reusable; its version tracks *design-system* change, not VPN-feature change), but its release tags carry the §11.4.151 project prefix when cut as part of a HelixVPN release wave.

Change class	Bump	Examples
MAJOR	breaking token rename/removal, component API break, export-form schema break	rename color.action→color.primary; drop a component; change the Dart ThemeExtension shape
MINOR	additive — new token, new component variant, new export target, new preset	add state.success-alt; add the C-Qt target; add a new icon
PATCH	value-only / fix — recolor within contrast, fix a dark value, doc/asset fix	nudge blue.600; fix a failing dark- contrast pair

- The submodule's VERSION + CHANGELOG.md are the source of truth; the §11.4.65 export pipeline keeps .md/.html/.pdf in sync, the §11.4.44 revision header on each doc.
 - A consuming app pins a **tag** (or a commit), and bumps the pointer deliberately (§11.4.26 step 7 pointer-bump discipline); a pointer bump that changes tokens triggers the app's visual-regression suite (§12, DS-I5).
 - Release tags follow §11.4.151: <PREFIX>-helix_design-<semver> when cut in a HelixVPN wave, plain helix_design-<semver> when cut standalone. **No force-push, ever** (§11.4.113) — every publish is a merge-onto-latest-main fast-forward to all mirrors.
-

9. The consumption model (how ANY app incorporates it)

9.1 The per-app pull recipe (the same five steps for every app)

```
# 1. Add the decoupled submodule at the FLAT parent-root path
    (§11.4.28(C)/.29):
git submodule add git@github.com:vasic-digital/helix_design.git
    helix_design

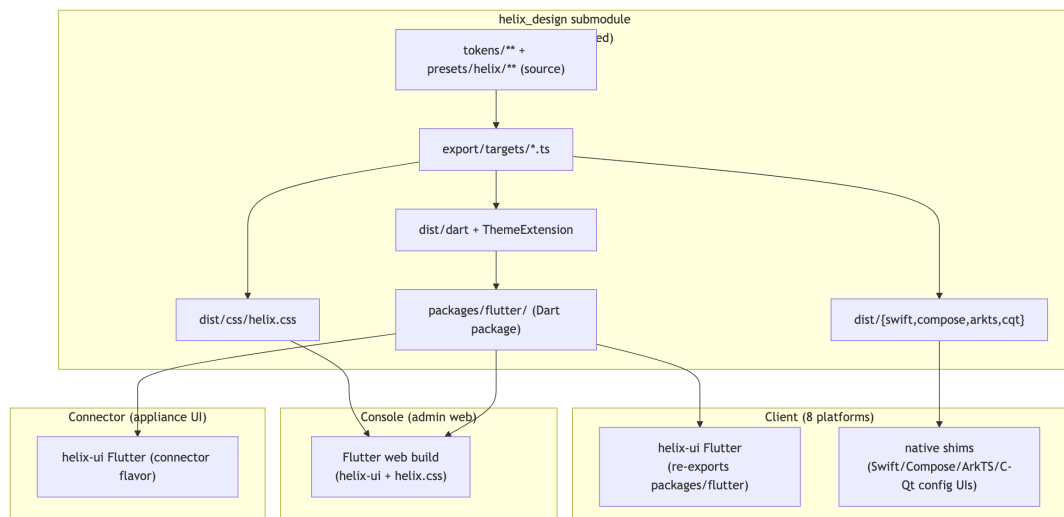
# 2. Install upstream push mirrors (§11.4.36):
( cd helix_design && install_upstreams )

# 3. Choose the brand preset (HelixVPN apps use presets/helix/; a
    future app drops its own):
#   (default is presets/helix/ – no flag needed for HelixVPN)

# 4. Generate the export form(s) the app needs (DS-I6 – never
    hand-copy tokens):
( cd helix_design && pnpm install && pnpm export )      # →
    dist/<target>/

# 5. Wire the generated form into the app build:
#   – Flutter app → depend on helix_design/packages/flutter
    (path/replace), apply HelixTheme
#   – Web surface → import dist/css/helix.css
#   – Apple shim → add dist/swift/HelixTokens.swift to the NE-
    extension target
#   – Android shim → add dist/compose/HelixTokens.kt
#   – HarmonyOS → add dist/arkts/helix_tokens.ets
#   – Aurora → include dist/cqt/helix_tokens.h + the .qml
    resource
```

9.2 How the three HelixVPN apps consume it



All three apps are built from one Flutter codebase via flavors + capability gating [04_CLIENT §5], so the Flutter package is the *primary* consumer; the native forms cover the platform-native surfaces the Flutter app cannot reach (§6). The Console Web build adds `dist/css/helix.css` for any non-Flutter web chrome.

9.3 How a FUTURE app incorporates it

Identical five steps, with step 3 dropping a new presets/`<app>/` (its own seed, palette, fonts) — and it inherits the entire token/theme/component/export machinery with **zero** HelixVPN coupling (DS-I1, the §2.1 reuse payoff). The §12 decoupling test is this scenario, run in CI-equivalent local sweeps.

10. Relationship to OpenDesign (§11.4.162)

Full, web-verified detail is in the sibling [opendesign-foundation.md]. This section states only the *relationship* `helix_design` [?] OpenDesign at the submodule level.

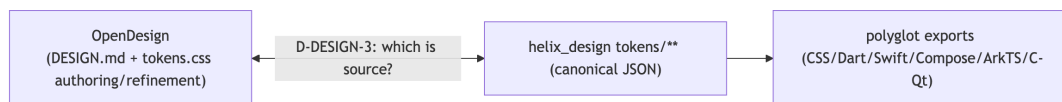
10.1 OpenDesign is the design-and-refinement system; `helix_design` is the distribution layer

Per §11.4.162, OpenDesign (<https://github.com/nexu-io/open-design>) is the **mandatory** system for *designing and refining* HelixVPN's UI — no ad-hoc CSS, no one-off tools. From the web-verified facts (see sibling doc):

- OpenDesign is a **local-first generative design tool** — a desktop app + CLI (`od`) + MCP server — that authors/refines design artifacts and design *systems*, consumed via CLI/MCP rather than as an npm package dependency (verified 2026-06-25).
- An OpenDesign **design system** is a folder `design-systems/<slug>/` containing `DESIGN.md` (a 9-section markdown spec), `tokens.css` (compiled CSS custom properties), `components.html`, `manifest.json`, plus `assets/` `fonts/` `preview/` `source/` (verified).

So `helix_design` **authors a HelixVPN OpenDesign design system** under `helix_design/opendesign/helix/` (`DESIGN.md` + `tokens.css` + `manifest.json`), uses OpenDesign to design/refine/preview it, and then **`helix_design`'s own exporters** (§6) translate the canonical token source into the polyglot forms OpenDesign does not itself produce. OpenDesign owns *authoring + refinement + the CSS/markdown design-system form*; `helix_design` owns *the canonical JSON source + the polyglot distribution*.

10.2 Direction of truth (open decision)



D-DESIGN-3 (open). Two candidate directions: **(a)** the OpenDesign `tokens.css` is the human-authored source and `helix_design` *imports* it into the canonical JSON (`tokens.css` → `tokens/**`), or **(b)** the JSON tiers are the source and `tokens.css` is a *generated export target* (one more export/targets/`css.ts` output) that OpenDesign then consumes/previews. This document leans **(b)** — JSON-as-source keeps the three-tier primitive→semantic→component model and light+dark theming first-class (which a flat `tokens.css` does not natively express), with `tokens.css` round-tripped for OpenDesign. (a) is simpler if designers live entirely in OpenDesign. Resolved at the Volume-10 review with the design team; UNVERIFIED until ratified.

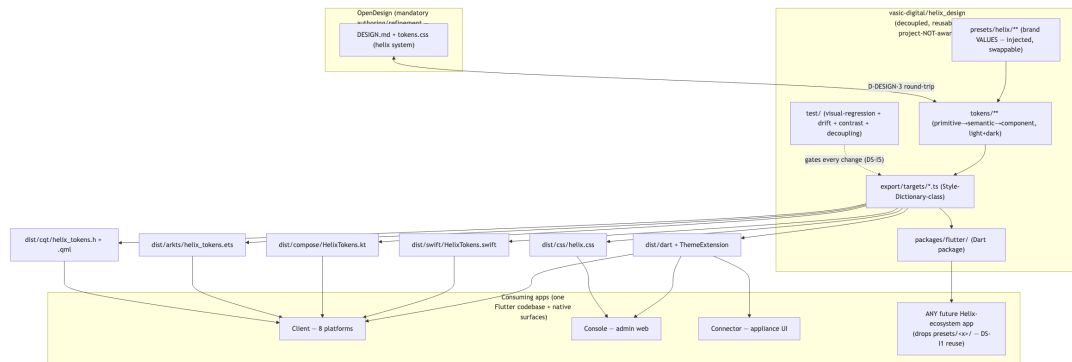
10.3 The OpenDesign-native folder

```
helix_design/opendesign/helix/
├─ manifest.json      # schemaVersion, id, name, category,
description, source, files{}
├─ DESIGN.md         # 9-section: visual theme, color, type,
spacing, layout, components,
|                     # motion, voice/tone, anti-patterns
(verified section model)
├─ tokens.css         # compiled CSS custom properties (light +
dark) – round-trip with §6
├─ components.html
└─ assets/ fonts/ preview/ source/
```

10.4 Extend-upstream policy (§11.4.74)

If OpenDesign lacks a pattern HelixVPN needs (e.g. a richer multi-theme token model, a new export form, a VPN-specific component archetype), the fix is a **PR to nexu-io/open-design** (extend the catalogue tool upstream), recorded with a Catalogue-Check: `extend nexu-io/open-design@<sha>` tracker line per §11.4.74 — **never** a private fork-and-diverge inside `helix_design`. The honest boundary (DS-I7): OpenDesign governs design tokens, themes, and the design-system form — it does **not** replace functional testing (§11.4.27), the all *behaviour* assertions, or the §11.4.48/.49 UI-driven test methodology; those stay in Volumes 4/8.

11. Architecture diagram (submodule → exporters → consuming apps)



12. Quality, testing, and gates owned here

helix_design is an equal-codebase submodule (§11.4.28(A)), so it carries the full anti-bluff testing floor (§11.4.169) for a design system. Deepened in [visual-regression-and-qa.md]; the gates owned at the submodule level:

Gate	Asserts	Class
DS-DRIFT	dist/** regenerated from tokens/** is byte-identical to a fresh pnpm export; a hand-edited derived form FAILs (DS-I6)	§11.4.12 drift
DS-LIGHT-DARK-COMPLETE	every semantic color token + every component spec defines BOTH light and dark (DS-I3)	§11.4.162
DS-CONTRAST	every on-X / X pair clears WCAG AA in light AND dark (DS-I5)	a11y (static, captured-evidence)
DS-NO-OVERLAP	golden screenshots show no overlapping elements / no label overlay (DS-I4)	§11.4.162 + §11.4.168 visual
DS-VISUAL-REGRESSION	per-component golden screenshots (light+dark) match the baseline within perceptual tolerance	§11.4.162 + §11.4.107(10) self-validated analyzer
DS-DECOUPLING	a build with a <i>non-HelixVPN</i> preset emits all forms green + zero HelixVPN refs in machinery (DS-I1)	§11.4.28(B) CM-OWNED-SUBMODULE-DECOUPLING

Gate	Asserts	Class
DS-EXPORT-FORM-VALID	each emitted form parses in its target toolchain (Dart analyze, swiftc parse, kotlinc, tsc/ArkTS, C compile)	§11.4.110 build-readiness
DS-SCHEMA	tokens/** validate against export/schema/ JSON-schema	§11.4.110

Honest boundary (DS-I7): these gates prove the *design system's* internal correctness + visual integrity. They do **not** prove a consuming app's feature works — that is the app's functional/UI-driven testing (Volumes 4/8). A green `helix_design` is necessary, not sufficient, for a shipped UI.

13. Open decisions surfaced by this document

ID	Decision	Lean	Resolves at
D-DESIGN-1	One <code>helix_design</code> submodule (Flutter pkg + polyglot bundle together) vs. two sibling submodules	(a) one submodule	Volume-10 review
D-DESIGN-2	<code>dist/</code> gitignored-and-regenerated vs. committed (Dart-only consumers want no Node toolchain)	gitignore <code>dist/</code> , check in the Flutter package's generated Dart as package-source	Volume-10 review + §11.4.30 audit
D-DESIGN-3	Source-of-truth direction: OpenDesign <code>tokens.css</code> → JSON, vs. JSON → <code>tokens.css</code> export	JSON-as-source (keeps tiers + light/dark first-class)	Volume-10 review with design team
D-DESIGN-4	Whether the polyglot native exporters are <code>helix_design</code> -owned (this doc) vs. contributed upstream to OpenDesign so OpenDesign emits them	<code>helix_design</code> -owned now; upstream-contribute opportunistically per §11.4.74	post-MVP
D-DESIGN-5	Font licensing/distribution: bundle	per-platform (bundle where license	Volume-10 assets doc

ID	Decision	Lean	Resolves at
	font files in assets/ fonts/ vs. reference system/Google fonts per platform	permits; reference otherwise)	

Sources verified

- **OpenDesign tool facts** (what it is, how it is consumed, DESIGN.md/tokens.css design-system structure) — verified against <https://github.com/nexu-io/open-design> and its QUICKSTART.md + design-systems/README.md, accessed **2026-06-25**. Full quotes and the per-fact verification table are in the sibling [opendesign-foundation.md] "Sources verified" footer. The critical finding that OpenDesign does **not** itself emit Dart/Swift/Compose/ArkTS/C-Qt (so the polyglot exporters are helix_design's own) is grounded there, not assumed.
- **Constitution clauses** §11.4.28 (equal-codebase + decoupling + dependency-layout), §11.4.29 (snake_case naming), §11.4.30/§11.4.77 (no versioned build derivatives + regeneration mechanism), §11.4.31 (submodule-dependency-manifest), §11.4.36 (install_upstreams on clone), §11.4.74 (catalogue-first reuse / extend upstream), §11.4.113 (no force-push), §11.4.151 (release-prefix naming), §11.4.157 (GEMINI.md lockstep), §11.4.162 (OpenDesign UI design-system mandate), §11.4.168 (exported-doc visual validation), §11.4.169 (mandatory test types) — from the constitution submodule text embedded in this repo's constitution/CLAUDE.md, accessed **2026-06-25**.
- **HelixVPN product context** — MASTER_INDEX.md (Volume 10 block + roles), v04-client/helix-ui-flutter.md (the helix_design Flutter package, the 5-variant TunnelStatus, projectUiState, the native-shim languages), SPECIFICATION.md (roles Client/Console/Connector, 8 platforms) — this repo, accessed **2026-06-25**.
- All token values, layout shapes, exporter target list, and decisions are **HelixVPN's own original design work** (NO external source needed) — except where a fact about OpenDesign is cited above; those are web-verified, and every place this document *assumes* an OpenDesign behaviour it could not verify is tagged UNVERIFIED inline.